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SEEKING ANSWERS Investigators at the AI-171 crash site in Ahmedabad, Jun. 13

HINDUSTAN TIMES

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STILL UNDER A CLOUD

The preliminary report on the Air India crash raises more questions than answers, with fuel switches and pilot actions under scrutiny

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

WHAT WAS MEANT TO CLARIFY the cause of one of India's deadliest aviation disasters has only added to the confusion. The preliminary report into the June 12 crash of the London-bound Air India flight in Ahmedabad—in which 260 people perished—was made public past midnight on July 11. But rather than offer closure, the 15-page document from the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) left experts and the public grappling with new uncertainties. Was it pilot error? A systems failure? Or, disturbingly, a deliberate act?

Events then thickened the intrigue. The report appeared to absolve Boeing, the 787-8 Dreamliner manufacturer, and engine-maker GE Aerospace, stating there were no safety advisories warranted. But the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) changed tack on July 15. The regulator directed all Indian operators of certain Boeing aircraft—including the 787 and 737 series—to urgently inspect their fuel control switches. This was in line with a US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) 'advisory', issued six years ago. According to the DGCA, several international carriers were already carrying out these checks. Indian opera-